

### Data Transfer

Given an average of 15 hours of playback time on a single charge, spending a couple of minutes to transfer songs should not be a dig deal. But, when a player is used as a thumb drive, the transfer rate becomes a parameter to consider. Transferring 100 MB of data to models with USB 2.0 takes about 15 seconds, while the slower ones with a USB 1.1 take a lethargic 190-odd seconds. If you intend to use your player to frequently transfer files between PCs, look at USB 2.0 models.

### Battery Type And Life

One of the ways of cutting costs and simplifying circuitry is by making the players run on standard AAA or AA batteries instead of internal rechargeable ones. This is the philosophy we saw followed in the entry-level segment. The XFREE XFL and MSI Megaplayer series lasted eight hours of continuous use, while the Creative Muvo series served twice that much with 16 hours. The Samsung YP C1 ran a full day on a single AA cell. The higher-end

Photographs Sandeep Patil



models sport rechargeable Lithium-ion polymer batteries, which have a longer life. The downside is that you need a PC's USB port (or an optional AC adaptor) to charge them. Coming close to the 20-hour bracket were the YES 920 and 922, Samsung's YP Z5, and the Sony NW series.

### In Conclusion

This contest was a close one and well fought. Brave attempts by manufacturers—a cube-shaped player, video playback on painfully tiny screens, a PC lock feature, multi-colour backlights, a player embedded in sunglasses (*refer page no. 62*) and what not! *Digit* lauds these attempts—this is how products get better and better for us!

Give or take a feature from a player, and the results could have been different. In our contest this time, the winner was from a brand somewhat less-known. Its features, value for money, a GB of storage, and of course, good sound quality helped the SAFA Q100 take the *Digit* Best Buy Gold honours. We found little to complain about with this player. A job well done, SAFA!

## Graphic Equalisers And Music Volume

Your music system has a 12-band equaliser, the MP3 player you are going to buy has a six-band equalizer, and so on. But does it matter? Why has *Digit* conducted the audio tests with the equalisers turned off? How many times have you tried playing with those controls, only to realise that your music actually sounds odd or even bad? The reality is that equaliser control is an unduly-hyped feature in audio systems.

An equaliser is meant to fine-tune the audio system to the environment where it is placed, and not to change the music itself—though most home users do precisely that. Let us gain an understanding of what frequencies are. The music you hear is composed of frequencies spread from 20 to 20,000 Hz in theory (practically, though, most people hear sounds from about 50 Hz to about 15,000 Hz). Different instruments and voices give out different frequencies. For example, the drums give low-frequency sounds called the bass, the treble is the high frequencies, such as the higher sounds of a violin, and the “mids”—the frequencies that fall in the middle of the range—are typically dominated by voice. An equaliser allows you to increase or decrease a particular set of frequencies, thereby altering the levels of various instruments and voices.

When it comes to music, it is the job of the music director to play with the levels of various tones and instruments. He is presumed to be competent enough to choose the best settings for his song, knowing well all the instruments that have gone into its making. When you change the settings on your system, you will be throwing away the sensibilities of the music creator, losing out on the intended experience.

Sometimes, the ambience of the room where a system is placed will affect the way certain frequencies come across to us. To offset this variation, equalisers are provided so that after careful observation, the user can negate the effect of the environment (such as furniture and curtain placement). Another use that equalisers find (though this was not originally intended) is to overcome some shortcomings of a system. For example, take the

case of a typical entry-level MP3 player that does not produce treble at the same level as the bass. When connected to a music system, you can neutralise this effect by sliding the bass control down or the treble control up.

In many cases, simply keeping the equaliser off will provide you with the best sound. Even when you need to change the settings, the amount of change should not be more than 20 per cent. If you need to change the levels more than this, there's something seriously wrong with your speakers or with the player itself.

You might want to move the equaliser settings about if, for example, you love bass and want more of a thumping effect—or, for that matter, for highlighting any particular instrument. But remember that what you'll be listening to isn't what the music director intended!

### Don't Play With Your Ears

When you play your music loud, it is not just your neighbours who have a problem: your ears are complaining too! Prolonged listening to loud music, whether through headphones or speakers, is harmful to your ears and can lead to tinnitus (ringing in the ears) and even hearing loss. This is a fact acknowledged even by manufacturers. Apple, in fact, recently released a firmware upgrade that allows a user to switch on a “safe” mode, in which the volume cannot be increased beyond a particular safe point. This preference can be turned off if the user wants to.

How do you know if the volume is too high for your ear? The answer is simple—if sustained hearing for more than 10 minutes causes even slight discomfort, it is too high! Do not ignore the discomfort—you will lose your sensitivity for low-volume sounds, and your pain threshold will increase. If you're already listening at high volumes and can't sense any discomfort, you probably have people around you who are complaining (in the case of speakers, at least), and it's time to move the volume knob to the left. Enjoy your music, but watch the volume!